

TV NEWS

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

It's 9 p.m. and as India pops the rice into the microwave and slumps into sofas, a *Kuch Kuch Hota Hai* begins unfolding on Aaj Tak—a senior BCCI official has frowned on Shah Rukh Khan's pre-release guerilla marketing strategy of watching a cricket match with his *Om Shanti Om* heroine Deepika Padukone. A cocktail of two heady national brews—cricket and Bollywood—challenged by India's premier cricketing body. Prime time gold.

Inside the studios of India's most popular news channel, half-a-dozen pairs of eyes sit transfixed on a long bank of TV monitors and control panels. This is the last point before TV signals run at the speed of light up a satellite dish and bounce back to earth, off an

NEWS MAKERS: Counting down to go live

20%

is the rate at which the news market is growing as a genre annually

orbiting satellite into the 75 million satellite and cable TV homes of post-liberalisation India. The state-of-the-art studios are in sharp contrast to that glorious era of inanity in the 1980s when the state decided what its impressionable citizens would watch. News was what a matronly Salma Sultan gently unfolded before the viewers—every loving detail of ribbon-cutting ceremonies by the prime minister and his entire cabinet. Cut to the present, India's satellite homes have 300 channels to choose from, of which more than 60 are of news and current affairs. Understandably then, attention spans are shrinking, fingers twitch on remote controls as channels break for advertisements. The basket is ever-increasing and all channels, entertainment and news, are fighting for

Live ACTION

Angry serpents, falling-in-pit babies, zombie tantriks and beaded astrologers. They all qualify for breaking news on one or the other of the country's 60-plus news channels.

